SONAM TSHERING

Associate Professor/Associate Dean
Jigme Singye Wangchuck School of Law

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Professional Summary: A legally trained professional and senior academic with over a decade of experience in contract law, dispute resolution, legal drafting, and stakeholder engagement. Has over 15 years of diverse experience in academia, public service, and legal practice, specializing in contract law, dispute resolution, mediation, privacy, public procurement, commercial drafting and arbitration. A Bar Council-certified Jabmi (Legal Counsel) and certified mediator, with formal training in arbitration, negotiation, and international dispute resolution. Currently Associate Professor and Associate Dean for Research and Library Services at JSW Law, Bhutan's only law school, and a founding faculty member recognized for academic leadership, integrity, and neutrality. Professional background includes service as public prosecutor, investigator, trainer, and legal advisor, Parliamentary Committee Secretary, and Legislative Officer with significant contributions to legislative drafting and policy reform in Bhutan. Experienced in teaching commercial law, arbitration agreement drafting, and conflict management, while also contributing legal commentaries through a long-running weekly column in Kuensel over seven years educating the public on their rights and critically looking at laws and policies. Internationally recognised with awards such as the WHO Regional Director's Award, he is known for analytical thinking, fairness, and confidence, actively seeking opportunities to serve as arbitrator.

EDUCATION

1. George Washington Law School, USA.
Master of Laws (LL.M.) in Contract Law

2. Bharati Vidyapeeth University, Pune, India.
Bachelor of Law (LL.B.)

3. Royal Institute of Management, Bhutan.
Post Graduation in National Law (Bhutanese Law)

4. University of Delhi, Sherubtse College, Bhutan.
Bachelor of Science

EXPERIENCE

Jigme Singye Wangchuck School of Law, Paro, Bhutan.

Associate Professor & Assistant Dean 2017 - Present

Founding faculty member with leadership experience in establishing and managing key academic and administrative departments. Developed and taught core law courses including Contract Law, Public and Government Contracts, Commercial and Arbitration Agreements, Procedural Laws, and ADR-related subjects. Served as Project Manager for The Asia Foundation funded justice and governance project (2020–2024), organized national legal forums, and supervised policy drafting, legislative research, and ethical review. Brings extensive practical experience in contractual dispute settlement, contract drafting, and advisory services, including legal advisory roles for major institutions, pro bono consultancy for government initiatives, and ongoing private contractual assignments.

Druk Justice Legal Consultancy, Woochu, Paro.

Chief Legal Counsel 2020 - Present

Advisor on high-value contracts and dispute resolution for corporates and government agencies. Extensive private practice in drafting, consultancy and settlement of private/corporate contractual and legal disputes.

National Assembly Secretariat, Parliament of Bhutan.

Legal Officer & Committee Secretary 2016 - 2017

Legal analysis and support for Parliamentary Committees on legislation, public accounts and good governance. Facilitated public hearings, legal research, and report drafting.

Bhutan Narcotic Control Authority, Bhutan.

Legal Advisor & Enforcement Officer 2010 - 2016

Advised on implementation of national and international laws; state prosecutor; legal trainer; project management with WHO and UNODC. Led legal research, enforcement training, public advocacy, and legislative drafting.

OTHER RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

Professional Development and affiliations:

1. Institute of Happiness, Bhutan (Major Think Tank), *Legal advisor and Expert on Contracts.* 2020 - 2024

2. First National Conference on Public Contracts Law, JSW Law, *Coordinator and presenter.* 2022

3. Technical Education and Vocational Educational Institute Reform, Prime Minister's Office, Bhutan, *Pro-bono Consultancy Service provider.* 2020-2021

4. *Contractual Dispute Settlement & Agreement Drafting for private entities and companies.*

5. Queensland University of Technology, Australia, and Bhutan National Legal Institute, Bhutan, *Certified trainer.*

6. Bar Council of Bhutan, *Member.*

7. Bhutan National Legal Institute, *Trained in legal drafting.*

8. UNEP & NEC, *Trained in Green Public Procurement Management.*

9. Legal Eagles, *Basic legal principles and interpretation of statutes consultant.*

10. World Health Organization, South East Asian Region, *Regional Director's Awardee.*

11. Centre for Science and Environment, South Asia, *First Media Fellowship Awardee.*

Skills:

Dispute resolution & arbitration advocacy **|** Legal research & analytical reasoning | Legislative and policy drafting | Contract drafting and review (public and private) | Stakeholder engagement & training delivery | Mediation, ADR, and negotiation | Communications & cross-sectoral coordination

Languages:

Dzongkha | English | Tshangla (can understand well) | Hindi (working proficiency)